situation will be reversed: the Chinese will have escalation dominance including in respect of nuclear weapons.

A final caveat relates to military technologies not dealt with earlier, namely, cyber, automated, and remotely operated devices married to artificial intelligence (AI) – what the Chinese call 'informatized warfare' and what the US calls 'net-centric capability'. The future battlefield is in a sense already here. The advanced militaries around the world have and are developing capabilities in all these areas. In essence, in addition to conventional and nuclear weapons, militaries will depend on cyber communications and the internet to orchestrate attack and defence using humans but also automated devices such as robots and drones. In the mix will be AI capabilities which will process huge volumes of data, interpret them, and use them to provide real-time options to humans and machines in the field. The AI systems may even be programmed to make decisions.

The battlefield will not just be on land, air, and sea but also in the virtual realm, with computers attacking and deceiving each other to disrupt enemy decision-making and actions. War will involve terrestrial and virtual battlefields as also hostilities in the exo-atmosphere and deep space. Operating such a system requires well-educated personnel at every level, organizational changes in the military, and integration of new technologies into expanded command-and-control systems. Indications are that the Chinese military is ahead on all counts. These new systems are 'force multipliers' and can enhance firepower and military effectiveness massively. In this sense, the relatively even military balance between India and China could rapidly become imbalanced.

How much difference the new technologies can make in the remote Himalaya at extremely low temperatures and at great heights is unknown, but their existence complicates strategy. Also, of course, the Chinese have not been at war since 1979 (when they invaded Vietnam) and therefore have not used their systems in real conditions. All in all, though, India must be counted as being at a considerable disadvantage in this domain. Lora Saalman, an expert on Indian and Chinese AI capabilities, in a recent assessment, concludes: 'The difference in [AI] capacity between India and